

Jim D. Pham
Share Your Favorite Websites
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Please post a list of at least (5) of your favorite websites and share with us why you like these websites.

Utilizing technology as a modeling tool is akin to brainstorming and analyzing a problem. Computer visual aids provide users with visual and conceptual representations of the issues they face. Typically, a problem is deconstructed into several manageable or understandable components, each representing a challenging area or a facet of the problem the user seeks to resolve. This analytical approach is similar to traditional problem analysis or the process of searching for information relevant to a specific issue. A visual representation or model serves as a blueprint for a problem, making it significantly easier to comprehend than verbal explanations or written descriptions. As the saying goes, “a picture is worth a thousand words.” Generally, people grasp a problem more effectively when it is presented as common-sense knowledge—comprising rules and facts—or when it is framed as interactive activities or manageable segments. This approach to thinking, known as thinking by modeling, allows for a more relatable connection to real-world scenarios.

Our textbook states that learning through modeling fundamentally involves problem-solving, which requires a degree of passivity in thought. I believe that solving problems via modeling encompasses various aspects and requires a diverse set of skills. The concept of modeling phenomena includes elements such as modeling domain knowledge, systems, problems, experiences, and the act of thinking. I think these modeling techniques demand a broad range of skills. However, I question how many individuals without a technical background truly grasp the concept of modeling domain knowledge in databases. One thing is clear: database modeling requires a specific set of skills that not everyone—including some technical professionals—can easily master—skills related to tables and fields, primary and foreign keys, and the relationships among them, among others.

I am teaching advanced .NET Programming this semester, and one of the key assignments for the class is to design a “Bank Account Manager.” A significant component of this task involves developing a data model in a relational database that incorporates the fundamental concepts of a Bank Account Manager. Whether one is engaged in design or modeling, critical thinking skills are essential for addressing challenges ranging from the smallest details to the broader system. I take pride in noting that my students are already honing their abilities to model complex phenomena.

Thinking by modeling is a skill that can be taught, much like any other skill. In today's rapidly advancing technological landscape, it can be challenging to stay up to date or achieve expertise in various fields. One of my strategies is to know my reliable sources of information and how to access them, as modeling and designing fundamentally rely on this knowledge. The Internet is vast and flooded with information, making it essential to

discern quality content from unreliable sources. This skill is particularly important for this week's exercise. While I have numerous technical links, I won't overwhelm you with exhaustive details. Here are five websites that I find valuable:

<http://www.google.com>

I find it essential to know how to search effectively. Among all search engines—such as MSN, Yahoo, WebCrawler, and Netscape—Google is my preferred choice.

<http://www.wikipedia.org/>

This is my encyclopedia. This website saves me many trips to the library. If you want something quick and precise, then this is a site for you.

<http://www.dictionary.com>

English is my second language, and dictionary.com is a website I can't live without. There are just too many vocabulary words in the English language.

For my kids, I often visit <http://www.readinga-z.com> and <http://www.edhelper.com>

www.readinga-z.com provides an extensive selection of printable level reading books ranging from pre-kindergarten to 6th grade. Each book is accompanied by reading comprehension worksheets and vocabulary development activities. The site also emphasizes creating preschool activities focused on letter formation, the alphabet, and letter sounds. I particularly appreciate the assessment tools and outstanding resources that help identify areas where my child may need improvement. These books are well-crafted and appropriately aligned with developmental levels.

In comparison, www.edhelper.com offers a variety of activities for preschool through 12th grade. This site specializes in helping teachers create lesson plans aligned with monthly themes. Therefore, it provides printed reading materials and worksheets, math, language arts (spelling and vocabulary), social studies, and even science. Its reading books are poorly written, and its accompanying worksheets don't effectively measure comprehension. In addition, this site does not allow teachers and parents to access the levels of their students.